

Q What things could I be putting in place now that will benefit my child's future?

There are a number of issues that may not have worried you too much until you had a baby and became a responsible parent. The issues discussed below are worth considering and prioritizing.

While many of these are financial, such as whether you want to start a savings account for private schooling or college, some are practical, such as leaving a will and assigning guardians to your new child if anything happens to you and your partner. You may also like to consider "legacy"

issues such as family stories, letters, heirlooms, and cultural matters (particularly if there are varied nationalities in the family) you would like your child to read or know about in the future. Here is a checklist for some of the things you may want to put in place.

PLANNING FOR THE FUTURE



SAVINGS ACCOUNTS AND FUNDS

Whether starting to save now for her future education or first home, or a trust to safeguard your child from having large tax bills in the future, you may want to consider setting up a bank account now.



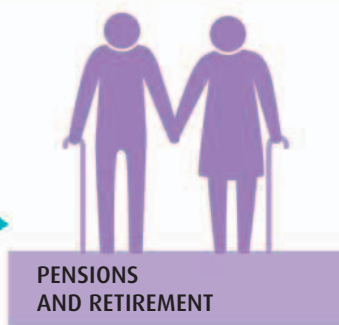
INSURANCE

Look at life and health insurance since you may want to increase your plans now that a child is in your life, so you are financially covered if something happens to you or your partner. If you have private health or dental plans, you should add the name of your baby.



WILLS AND GUARDIANSHIP

Set up a will to avoid leaving the fate of your child's guardianship and your assets in the court's hands. Assign a guardian who would be able to step in to raise your child, if the worst happened, and help her with her education, health, and keep her safe and taken care of until she is an adult.



PENSIONS AND RETIREMENT

It may seem a long way off but you will want to make sure that there is sufficient money in the pot for you later in life, so that the burden of old age and what it may bring with it doesn't fall on your child.

Q We definitely want to become pregnant again. Is there an ideal age gap between siblings?

There are pros and cons for different age gaps, and your decision on when to try again is likely to be influenced by how you both feel about managing family life. You may feel that having a second baby while your first child is still very young means that you will be able to deal with the intense baby and toddler stages all at the same time. Your children are likely to be natural playmates and develop a strong bond, and can be companions when at school. Also, if you are planning to have a big family you may not want to wait too long before you have a second child. Some suggest, though, that siblings very close in age may squabble more when competing for toys and attention. Conversely, you may want to wait until your first child is out of diapers before considering another baby, so that you

have more time to dedicate both to your first child's early years and then to the new baby. Physically, this may also be more appealing, giving your body plenty of time to recover from the birth of your first baby, so that you have more energy for the new arrival. Financially, a bigger age gap means you may not need to invest in items such as a double stroller or an additional crib, and you can spread the cost of child care out over a longer period.

Q Healthwise, is there an optimal time to wait before getting pregnant again?

Both you, and your future baby, can benefit from having some space between pregnancies. Pregnancy and breast-feeding can deplete your reserves of essential nutrients such as folate and iron, so giving your body some time to

build these reserves before you conceive again can benefit both your own and your unborn baby's health. Furthermore, recent studies have shown that women who gave birth again within 18 months of having a baby were considerably more likely to have a premature delivery than those who waited longer to get pregnant again. Waiting at least 12–18 months after having a baby before conceiving again is thought to eliminate the increased risk of premature birth.

There are **factors** other than age, such as **personality** and **gender**, that will determine how well or not your **children** do.